of these events with the Pakistan army returning to its old game plan of using proxies to execute terror attacks in India, in a bid to strengthen its hold over the country. Their target this time is Jammu, the idea being to disrupt the assembly election in J&K and bring the Valley back to centre stage so that national security becomes a key issue in Pakistan again.

Meanwhile, China, too, has upped the ante in the past five years, first by unprecedented intrusions on the LAC in Galwan Valley in Ladakh in May 2020, which saw armed forces personnel lose their lives in clashes for the first time in 50 years. It then amassed troops in all key sectors of Ladakh and the Northeast. The border stand-off saw relations between the two countries plumb new nadirs and despite 21 rounds of military talks, China has refused to pull back from some of the vantage points it had occupied. India has now said that the relationship will remain abnormal till China restores status quo ante not only at the points it encroached in May 2020 but also its earlier transgressions in the Demchok and Depsang regions. China has gone back to its old formulation that the two countries not allow the border dispute to come in the way of normalisation on the trade and other fronts. Alongside, China has worked to actively woo India's neighbours through its Belt and Road Initiative (BRI), generously funding major infrastructure projects that help build connectivity and enhance trade with China. Sensing India's vulnerabilities in its relations with China, neighbouring countries have frequently played one against the other, often forcing New Delhi to go on the back foot and scramble to restore parity. Saran, however, warns, "The inordinate focus on only China as the root of all troubles in our neighbourhood is misplaced. We should examine whether we have been at fault and may not have been delivering while dealing with our neighbours."

PAKISTAN



FOR THE LEADER
Supporters of former Pakistan PM Imran Khan mark a year of his imprisonment in Swabi, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, Aug. 5

THE WAYS OUT

So, how does India reinvent and rejuvenate its Neighbourhood First policy? Most experts advocate a massive push towards economic integration with its neighbours and a willingness to spend big bucks as China did with BRI. Menon is among those who believe that India should move beyond security being the leitmotif of its neighbourhood policy and focus instead on providing economic stability and enhancing prosperity. He adds another important condition: India should not push for reciprocity with its neighbours but, like the doctrine enunciated by former prime minister I.K. Gujral, give them more than what we take from them. "If America insists on reciprocity in its relations with India, do you think our ties with it will move forward rapidly?" asks Menon. Tellis believes India should take a leaf out of China's playbook and work towards "making its enemies dependent on it". And economics is the one realm where you can get maximum leverage, which means India should pursue an aggressive trade policy that enhances regional integration. Saran agrees and says what's important is to have a range of such engagements that ensure "long-term interdependence" that can prevent "suicidal compulsions" for incoming hostile political dispensations. Gupta believes a new dimension should be added to the country's neighbourhood policy in which "India fights its battles in the economic and financial front rows too".



"INDIA SHOULD BE MORE ENGAGED WITH ALL PLAYERS IN NEPAL AND NOT PUT ALL ITS EGGS IN ONE BASKET, AS IT DID IN BANGLADESH"

– RANJIT RAE
Former ambassador to Nepal

Sri Lanka is a good example of how the Modi government played its cards well after the economic crisis of 2022 plunged the island-nation into uncertainty. Before that, China had wooed Sri Lanka with investments worth over $13 billion which included major infrastructure projects, related mainly to ports and urban development. But many of these proved to be white elephants and Sri Lanka's debt to GDP ratio crossed an unsustainable 110 per cent. The economy was on the verge of collapse after Covid saw remittances dry up, the tourism industry crash and inflation in food, fertiliser and petrol prices soar. That's when India stepped in and extended financial aid worth about $4 billion. And even as Chinese FDI dried up in the past four years, India pumped in close to $500 million in investments.